Neologisms: New and Improved

Marc Alexander · English Language & Linguistics 2A · Week 5

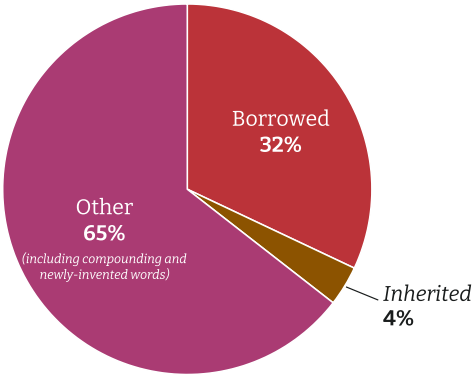


FIGURE 1 Pie chart of the sources of English words: Borrowed 32%, Inherited 4%, Other (including compounding and newly-invented words) 65%

*not a **real** word*

*a '**made-up**' word*

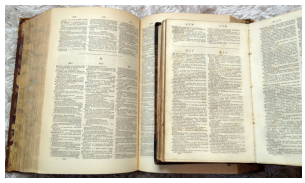


FIGURE 2 A large old dictionary lying open, its pages of small print yellowed with age



FIGURE 3 A police officer in a high-visibility vest blowing a whistle and pointing with an orange-gloved hand



FIGURE 4 People hauling blue fishing nets out of the sea on a beach at sunset



FIGURE 5 A detailed pen-and-ink bird's-eye map of Disneyland



FIGURE 6 A physical map of Scotland



FIGURE 7 A map of the Central Belt of Scotland, with Glasgow marked in orange between Loch Lomond and the Clyde



FIGURE 8 The same map of the Central Belt of Scotland, with Glasgow missing

1. New words?

~~*goed*~~ ***went***

~~*regaler*~~ ***more regal***

~~*gaven't*~~ ***didn't give***

~~*difficultness*~~ ***difficulty***

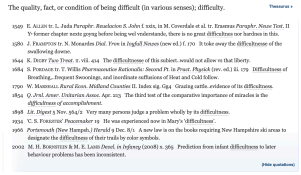


FIGURE 9 OED quotations for difficultness, 'The quality, fact, or condition of being difficult (in various senses); difficulty', from 1549 to 2002

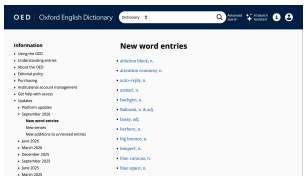


FIGURE 10 The OED's list of new word entries for September 2026, from ablution block to blue space

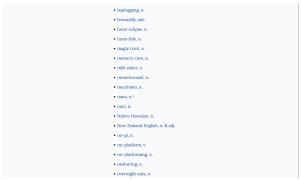


FIGURE 11 Further down the OED's list of new word entries, with every entry faded except mountweazel, n.



FIGURE 12 The OED entry for mountweazel, noun: an invented or fake entry in a reference work, used by the publisher to identify plagiarism, first published 2026

Neologisms: How Do We Get New Words?

2. Affixation

English affixes are used to create a **non-transparent** new word.

- *graceful/disgraceful*
- *spectacle/spectacles*
- *new/news*
- *hard/hardly*

3. Conversion

Take a word form from another part of speech.



FIGURE 13 Calvin and Hobbes strip. Calvin: 'I like to verb words.' Hobbes: 'What?' Calvin: 'I take nouns and adjectives and use them as verbs. Remember when "access" was a thing? Now it's something you do. It got verbed.' Calvin: 'Verbing weirds language.' Hobbes: 'Maybe we can eventually make language a complete impediment to understanding.'

- *access*
- *email*
- *fish*
- *smooth*
- *gaatekeep*
- *convict*
- *present*
- *refuse*
- *torment*
- *record, rebel*

4. Compounding

English **bases** are compounded together.

hovercraft	*hover + craft*
bonfire	*bone + fire*
holiday	*holy + day*
woman	*wife + man*
goodbye	*god + be + with + ye*
lord	*loaf + ward*
hussy	*house + wife*

5. De novo

Entirely new word invented by putting together letters/sounds.

- *flabbergast*
- *gizmo*
- *Muppet*
- *Kodak*
- *Quark*
- *Jedi*
- *Viagra*
- *Prozac*
- *Nylon*

6. Blending *(portmanteau)*

Taking parts of two words and merging them

brunch	*breakfast + lunch*
sitcom	*situation + comedy*
romantasy	*romance + fantasy*
blog	*web + log*
examnesia	*exam + amnesia*
tradwife	*traditional + wife*

7. Clipping

A shortened form of a word becomes a word in its own right.

flu	*influenza*
hyper	*hyperactive*
copter	*helicopter*
sci-fi	*science fiction*
gin	*Geneva/engine*
rizz	*charisma*

8. Back-formation

Creation of words by (mistaken) analogy.

- *to burgle*
- *to buttle*
- *cherry*
- *grovel*

9. Abbrev.

Taking the first letters, the first sounds, or the first few letters of words and combining them into a new word.

ACRONYMS

- *Nasa*
- *Shape*
- *Nato*
- *Laser*
- *Radar*
- *Modem*
- *Jeep*
- *Potus/Scotus*
- *Fubar/Snafu*
- *Lol (LOL?)*

INITIALISMS

- *FDR*
- *BBC*
- *UK*
- *AM/PM*
- *BC/AD*
- *CE/BCE*
- *MA/PhD*
- *LOL (Lol?)*
- *FAQ (Faq?)*
- *LLM*

10. Eponyms

Words from names.

- *watt*
- *kelvin*
- *boycott*
- *cardigan*
- *lynch*
- *nicotine*
- *cheddar*
- *denim*
- *port*
- *sherry*
- *atlas*
- *morphine/morph*
- *panic*
- *to Instagram*

11. Onomatopoeia

Emulating a sound in a word.

- *woof*
- *baa / bleat*
- *quack*
- *roar*
- *burble*
- *meow*
- *bang*
- *cuckoo*

12. Reduplication

When part or all of a word is repeated.

- *hip-hop*
- *bonbon*
- *ping-pong*
- *itty-bitty*
- *mish-mash*
- *fifty-fifty*